Northwind Outfitters Inc.

Refund, Return & Cancellation Policy Handbook

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NOTICE: Northwind Outfitters Inc. is a fictional demo company. All names, policies, amounts, phone numbers, email addresses and order numbers in this document are invented solely for testing document-processing, search and Q&A systems.

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1. Introduction and Scope

Northwind Outfitters Inc. ("Northwind", "we", "us") is a fictional online and retail seller of outdoor gear, apparel, camping equipment and accessories, headquartered in Portland, Oregon. This handbook describes our policies on refunds, returns, exchanges and cancellations for purchases made through northwind-demo.example, our mobile app, and our 42 retail stores.

Our guiding principle is simple: if you are not satisfied with your purchase, we want to make it right. This document is intended for customers, support agents, and finance staff, so that every refund decision is consistent, fair and transparent.

1.1 Who this policy applies to

- Retail customers purchasing for personal use in the United States, Canada, the UK and the EU.
- Marketplace customers purchasing Northwind-fulfilled items from third-party sellers (see Section 14).
- Business customers on standard accounts (custom contracts may override these terms).

1.2 Policy summary at a glance

Topic	Summary
Return window	30 days from delivery (60 days for Northwind Rewards Gold members)
Refund speed	3-5 business days after we receive and inspect the return
Return shipping	Free for defective or incorrect items; $6.95 deducted otherwise
Restocking fee	None on most items; 15% on special-order and bulk items
Final sale items	Not eligible for refund or exchange

2. Definitions

The following terms are used throughout this handbook with the meanings given below.

Term	Definition
Refund	Return of money to the original payment method or store credit following an approved return or cancellation.
Return	Sending a purchased item back to Northwind by mail or in-store drop-off.
Exchange	Replacing an item with a different size, colour or product of equal or greater value.
Store Credit	A balance issued to a customer account, redeemable online and in stores, valid for 5 years.
RMA	Return Merchandise Authorization number, e.g. RMA-2026-004815, required for mailed returns.
Delivery Date	The date the carrier marks the package as delivered, as shown in the tracking record.
Final Sale	Items marked 'Final Sale' at the time of purchase, which cannot be returned.
Original Condition	Unused, unwashed, with all tags, packaging and accessories included.
Business Day	Monday to Friday, excluding US federal holidays.

Where this handbook conflicts with applicable consumer protection law, the law prevails. Nothing in this policy limits statutory rights, including the 14-day cooling-off right for EU and UK distance purchases.

3. Standard Return Policy

Most items purchased from Northwind may be returned within **30 calendar days** of the delivery date (or purchase date for in-store sales) for a full refund of the item price, provided the item is in original condition.

3.1 Extended windows

Category / Situation	Return Window
Standard merchandise	30 days
Northwind Rewards Gold members	60 days
Holiday purchases (Nov 1 - Dec 24)	Until January 31 of the following year
Footwear (worn indoors only)	45 days
Camping tents and sleeping bags (unused)	60 days
Defective items	Covered by warranty - see Section 14

3.2 Returns without a receipt

Returns without proof of purchase are accepted in-store only, for store credit at the lowest price the item was sold in the last 90 days. A government-issued photo ID is required and scanned. A limit of three receipt-less returns per customer per 12-month period applies.

3.3 Exchanges

Exchanges for a different size or colour are free of charge, including shipping both ways, when requested within the return window and when the replacement item is in stock. If the replacement costs more, the difference will be charged; if less, the difference will be refunded.

4. Refund Eligibility Criteria

To be eligible for a refund, all of the following conditions must be met. Support agents must verify each condition before approving a refund over $50.00.

- The request is made within the applicable return window.
- The item is in original condition: unused, unwashed, undamaged, with original tags attached.
- The item is returned with all accessories, manuals, free gifts and original packaging where practical.
- The order number or proof of purchase can be verified in our systems.
- The item is not on the non-refundable list in Section 5.

4.1 Partial refunds

A partial refund may be issued when an item shows signs of use beyond inspection, is missing parts, or is returned without original packaging. Typical deductions are shown below.

Condition on arrival	Refund amount
Like new, tags attached	100%
Opened packaging, item unused	100%
Missing original box (non-fragile)	90%
Missing accessories or free gift	Refund minus gift value
Light wear or signs of use	50% - 75%
Damaged by customer / heavy use	0% - 25% (agent discretion, manager approval)
Washed, altered or stained	Not eligible

4.2 Manager approval thresholds

- Up to $100: Tier 1 agent may approve.
- $100.01 - $500: Tier 2 agent or team lead approval required.
- Over $500: Customer Experience Manager approval required.
- Over $2,000: Finance Director approval and fraud review required.

5. Non-Refundable Items

The following items cannot be returned or refunded, except where the item is defective or we sent the wrong item.

- Items marked **Final Sale** or **Clearance - All Sales Final** at checkout.
- Gift cards and e-gift cards (see Section 13).
- Downloadable software, digital guides and trail-map files once downloaded.
- Personalised or custom-engraved items, including monogrammed jackets and embroidered packs.
- Opened hygiene items: water bottles' mouthpieces, thermal underwear, socks, and swimwear without liner tags.
- Fuel canisters, bear spray, and other hazardous materials once opened or shipped.
- Perishable goods such as freeze-dried meals past 14 days from delivery.
- Installation, repair, and gear-fitting services already performed.
- Items returned more than 90 days after delivery.

5.1 Why some items are excluded

Hygiene, safety and legal regulations prevent us from restocking certain categories. For example, we cannot resell opened pressurised canisters. Custom products are made specifically for the customer and cannot be resold.

5.2 Exceptions

Even for non-refundable items, a full refund or replacement will be provided if the item arrives damaged, is materially different from its description, or was shipped in error. Report these issues within 7 days of delivery with photos.

6. How to Request a Refund

Customers can start a return through any of the following channels. Online requests are fastest and generate an RMA automatically.

6.1 Online (recommended)

- Sign in at northwind-demo.example/returns and select the order.
- Choose the items to return and select a reason from the list.
- Upload photos if the item is damaged or defective.
- Choose a refund method: original payment, store credit (bonus 5%) or exchange.
- Print the prepaid label (if eligible) or choose a QR-code drop-off at a partner location.

6.2 By phone or chat

Call 1-800-555-0142 (Mon-Fri 8am-8pm PT, Sat 9am-5pm PT) or use live chat. Please have your order number and email address ready. Agents will email your RMA and label within 1 hour.

6.3 In store

Bring the item, packaging and receipt or order confirmation to any Northwind store. In-store refunds to the original card are processed immediately; the bank may take 3-5 days to post the credit.

6.4 Information required

Field	Example	Required?
Order number	NW-10482391	Yes
Email on order	jane.doe@example.com	Yes
Item SKU / name	TNT-4P-GRN / Summit 4-Person Tent	Yes
Reason for return	Wrong size	Yes
Photos	Damage close-up	If damaged
Preferred resolution	Refund to card	Yes

7. Refund Processing Timelines

Refund timing depends on the stage of the process. The table below shows typical timelines. Business days exclude weekends and US federal holidays.

Stage	Typical Duration
RMA issued after request	Instantly online; up to 1 hour by phone
Return transit to warehouse	3-7 business days (domestic)
Warehouse receipt and inspection	1-2 business days
Refund approved and issued	Within 1 business day of inspection
Credit card refund posted by bank	3-5 business days
Debit card / bank transfer	5-10 business days
PayPal	Within 24 hours of issue
Store credit	Immediate
Check (by request, over $1,000)	10-15 business days

7.1 Example timeline

A customer ships a return on Monday, March 2. The package is delivered to our warehouse on Friday, March 6. Inspection is completed Monday, March 9, and the refund is issued that day. The customer's credit card statement shows the credit by Friday, March 13 at the latest.

7.2 Delays

If a refund has not appeared 10 business days after our confirmation email, please contact your bank first, then contact us with the refund reference number (format: REF-2026-XXXXXX). We will provide an Acquirer Reference Number (ARN) on request.

8. Refund Methods and Payment Types

Refunds are issued to the original form of payment whenever possible. This is required for fraud prevention and by card network rules.

Original payment	Refund method	Notes
Visa / Mastercard / Amex	Original card	3-5 business days to post
Debit card	Original card	Up to 10 business days
PayPal	PayPal balance	Usually within 24 hours
Apple Pay / Google Pay	Underlying card	Same as card
Buy Now Pay Later (e.g. Klarna)	Provider reduces balance	Provider timelines apply
Gift card	New gift card or store credit	Instant
Cash (in-store)	Cash up to $50, then store credit/card	ID required over $50
Split payments	Proportionally to each method	Gift card portion first

8.1 Store credit bonus

Customers who choose store credit instead of a refund to the original payment method receive a **5% bonus** on the credit value, up to $25. For example, a $200 return becomes $210 in store credit. Bonus credit cannot be applied retroactively once a refund has been issued to the card.

8.2 Expired or closed cards

If the original card has been closed or replaced, the bank will normally still forward the credit to the new card. If it is rejected, we will contact the customer by email within 5 business days to arrange store credit or a check.

9. Shipping Costs and Return Labels

Shipping costs are handled differently depending on the reason for return.

Reason	Original shipping refunded?	Return label cost
Defective or damaged	Yes, in full	Free
Wrong item sent	Yes, in full	Free
Not as described	Yes, in full	Free
Changed mind / wrong size	No	$6.95 deducted from refund
Gold member, any reason	No	Free
Exchange	N/A	Free both ways
Order over $150, any reason	No	Free

9.1 Oversize items

Large items such as kayaks, canoes and heavy tents ship via freight. Return freight for change-of-mind returns is a flat $49.00, deducted from the refund. Freight pickups must be scheduled with our logistics team at least 3 business days in advance.

9.2 Using your own carrier

Customers may use their own carrier. We recommend a tracked service with insurance, as Northwind is not responsible for returns lost in transit. Reimbursement for carrier costs is limited to $12.00 and only for approved defective returns, with a receipt.

9.3 Drop-off locations

Prepaid labels can be dropped at over 15,000 carrier locations and all Northwind stores. Keep the drop-off receipt until your refund has been confirmed.

10. Damaged, Defective or Incorrect Items

If your order arrives damaged, defective or incorrect, we will make it right with a replacement or a full refund, including original shipping, at your choice.

10.1 Reporting window

Please report issues within **7 days** of delivery for the fastest resolution. Reports up to 30 days are accepted for visible defects; hidden defects fall under the warranty (Section 14).

10.2 Evidence required

- Clear photos of the damaged item and the outer shipping box.
- Photo of the shipping label showing the order and tracking number.
- A short description of the issue.
- Video evidence for electronic or mechanical failures (recommended).

10.3 Resolution options

Option	Details	Timeline
Replacement	Same item shipped with free expedited shipping	2-3 business days
Full refund	Item price plus shipping and tax	3-5 business days
Partial refund (keep item)	Offered for minor cosmetic flaws	Immediate
Repair	For eligible products under warranty	7-14 business days

For damaged items valued under $40.00, we may issue a refund without requiring the item to be returned ("Keep It" policy), at the agent's discretion. This is limited to two instances per customer per year.

11. Order Cancellations

Orders can be cancelled at no cost before they ship. Once an order has shipped, it must be handled as a return.

Order status	Can it be cancelled?	Refund
Pending (within 1 hour)	Yes - self-service	Full refund, immediate release of authorisation
Processing	Yes - contact support	Full refund within 3-5 days
Packed, not shipped	Attempted - not guaranteed	Full refund if stopped, else return
Shipped	No	Refuse delivery or return
Delivered	No	Standard return policy
Pre-order	Yes, until 7 days before release	Full refund
Backordered	Yes, anytime	Full refund

11.1 Cancellations by Northwind

We may cancel an order for reasons including stock errors, pricing errors, suspected fraud, or inability to verify payment. In such cases, a full refund is issued automatically within 3 business days, and a 10% discount code may be provided where the cancellation was due to our error.

11.2 Price adjustments

If an item you purchased drops in price within 14 days of purchase, contact us for a one-time price adjustment refund of the difference. Limited to one adjustment per order. Doorbuster, flash-sale and marketplace items are excluded.

12. Subscription Refunds

Northwind offers the following subscriptions: **Trailhead Box** (monthly gear box, $39.00/month), **Northwind Rewards Plus** ($49/year), and **Gear Care Plan** ($9.99/month).

Subscription	Billing	Cancellation	Refund rule
Trailhead Box	Monthly, 1st of month	Anytime before the 25th	Full refund if cancelled within 48 hours of renewal and box not shipped
Rewards Plus	Annual	Anytime	Pro-rated refund within 30 days of renewal; none afterwards
Gear Care Plan	Monthly	Anytime	No refund for current month; cancel effective next cycle

12.1 Free trials

Rewards Plus offers a 14-day free trial. If you cancel before the trial ends, you will not be charged. If you forget to cancel and are charged, contact us within 7 days for a full refund of the first charge.

12.2 Accidental renewals

We send renewal reminders 7 days before annual renewals. If you did not receive a reminder due to an invalid email address, we will treat the renewal as accidental and refund in full within 30 days.

12.3 Pausing instead of cancelling

Trailhead Box subscribers can pause for up to 3 months, once per year, from the account page. Paused subscriptions are not billed.

13. Digital Products and Gift Cards

13.1 Digital products

Digital goods such as trail guides (PDF), camping-skills video courses, and map packs are non-refundable after download or streaming begins. If a file is corrupt or inaccessible, we will provide a working copy or a full refund within 14 days of purchase.

Video courses may be refunded within 7 days if less than 20% of the content has been viewed.

13.2 Gift cards

- Gift cards are not refundable for cash, except where required by law (e.g. California, balances under $10).
- Gift cards never expire and carry no fees.
- Lost or stolen gift cards can be replaced if the card number is provided, minus any used balance.
- Gift card purchases cannot be cancelled once the code is delivered by email.
- Fraudulently purchased gift cards will be voided and the associated payment refunded to the real cardholder.

13.3 Returning a gift

Gift recipients can return items with a gift receipt for store credit equal to the price paid, or exchange for another item. The purchaser is not notified of the return. Without a gift receipt, credit is issued at the lowest recent selling price.

13.4 Promotional credits

Promotional credits and coupon codes have no cash value. If an order paid with a promotional code is refunded, the code's value is returned as promotional credit, not as cash.

14. Warranty Claims vs. Refunds

A refund is a return of money for a purchase within the return window. A warranty claim addresses defects that appear later, during normal use.

Product Category	Warranty period	Remedy
Tents and shelters	2 years	Repair, replace or refund
Sleeping bags	Lifetime (manufacturing defects)	Repair or replace
Backpacks	5 years	Repair or replace
Footwear	1 year	Replace or refund
Apparel	1 year	Replace or refund
Electronics (headlamps, GPS)	1 year	Repair or replace
Stoves and cookware	2 years	Repair or replace
Water filters	1 year	Replace

14.1 What the warranty does not cover

- Normal wear and tear, fading, and gradual abrasion.
- Damage from misuse, accidents, improper cleaning or storage.
- Modifications or repairs by unauthorised parties.
- Damage from fire, flood, wildlife, or other external causes.

14.2 Marketplace sellers

Items sold by third-party sellers but fulfilled by Northwind are covered by this policy. Items shipped directly by third-party sellers follow the seller's policy, but Northwind's A-to-Z Guarantee ensures a refund if the seller fails to respond within 5 business days.

15. International Orders, Duties and Currency

Northwind ships to 38 countries. International returns follow the same eligibility rules, with the exceptions below.

Region	Return window	Return shipping	Duties and taxes
United States	30 days	See Section 9	Included
Canada	30 days	Customer pays unless defective	Duties refunded on approved returns
UK	30 days (14-day statutory minimum)	Customer pays unless defective	VAT refunded, duty via customs claim
EU	30 days (14-day statutory minimum)	Customer pays unless defective	VAT refunded
Australia	30 days	Customer pays unless defective	GST refunded
Rest of world	14 days	Customer pays	Not refundable

15.1 Currency conversion

Refunds are issued in the currency of the original charge. Exchange rate differences between the purchase and refund date are not compensated; the bank's rate on the refund date applies. For example, a EUR 100.00 purchase may be charged as $108.00 and refunded as $106.50 depending on exchange movement.

15.2 Customs and duties

Customers are responsible for filing customs duty drawback claims where available. Northwind will provide a commercial invoice and proof of return upon request. Refused deliveries at customs are refunded minus outbound and return shipping.

16. Chargebacks and Disputes

We encourage customers to contact us before initiating a chargeback with their bank. Most issues can be resolved faster directly, and a chargeback can lead to account restrictions.

16.1 Process

- Customer files a dispute with the card issuer.
- Our payment processor notifies us within 1-3 business days.
- We submit evidence (order record, delivery confirmation, communications) within 7 days.
- The issuer decides within 30-90 days.
- If the dispute is lost, funds are debited; a $15 administration fee may apply for fraudulent claims.

16.2 If you already received a refund

Please do not dispute a charge that has been refunded. Duplicate recoveries (refund plus chargeback) are treated as potential fraud, and the customer is liable for repayment.

16.3 Dispute reason codes

Code (example)	Meaning	Typical resolution
4853	Cardholder dispute / not as described	Refund or evidence submission
4837	No cardholder authorisation (fraud)	Fraud investigation
4855	Goods or services not provided	Provide tracking proof or refund
4834	Duplicate processing	Verify and refund duplicate
4841	Cancelled recurring transaction	Check cancellation record

17. Fraud Prevention and Abuse

Northwind monitors return activity to protect honest customers and prevent abuse. Our systems and agents look for patterns such as:

- Return rates exceeding 40% of purchases across a rolling 12-month period.
- Returning items that were not purchased from Northwind.
- Wardrobing - purchasing items for one-time use and returning them.
- Returning counterfeit or swapped items (e.g. an empty box, or a lower-grade item).
- Multiple accounts linked to the same address, device or payment method.
- Repeated claims of 'item not received' on delivered orders.

17.1 Consequences

Level	Trigger	Action
Notice	Return rate 30-40%	Email reminder of policy
Restricted	Return rate over 40% or one confirmed abuse case	Store credit only; returns need manager approval
Suspended	Multiple confirmed abuse cases	Account suspended for 12 months
Permanent	Fraud or counterfeit return	Account closed; referral to law enforcement where appropriate

17.2 Appeals

Customers may appeal restrictions in writing to appeals@northwind-demo.example within 30 days. Appeals are reviewed by a manager not involved in the original decision within 10 business days.

17.3 Privacy

Return history is stored per our Privacy Policy, retained for 7 years for audit purposes, and never sold to third parties.

18. Frequently Asked Questions

Q1. Can I return an item after 30 days?

Standard returns must be requested within 30 days. Gold members have 60 days. After that we may offer store credit at a manager's discretion for unused items within 90 days.

Q2. Will I get my shipping cost back?

Only if the return is due to our error or a defect. For change-of-mind returns, original shipping is not refunded.

Q3. How will I know my refund has been issued?

You will receive an email titled 'Your refund is on the way' containing the refund amount, method, and reference number such as REF-2026-077314.

Q4. I returned my item but have not received a refund. What should I do?

Check your tracking to confirm delivery, allow 2 business days for inspection and up to 5 more for your bank. If it has been more than 10 business days, contact support.

Q5. Can I return an item bought in-store through the website?

Yes. Items bought in-store can be returned in any store or by mail using the RMA process with your receipt or loyalty account lookup.

Q6. Do sale items qualify for a refund?

Regular sale items yes; items marked Final Sale or Clearance - All Sales Final no.

Q7. Can I get a cash refund?

Refunds go to the original payment method. Cash refunds are only available for cash purchases under $50.

Q8. What if my package was stolen after delivery?

Please file a police report and contact us within 14 days. We offer one courtesy replacement per customer per year for packages under $200.

Q9. Is my sales tax refunded?

Yes, tax is refunded proportionally with the item price.

Q10. Can I cancel part of my order?

Yes, if the order has not shipped. Contact support to remove specific items.

19. Contact Information and Escalation

Our customer care team is available through the following channels. All contact details below are fictional.

Channel	Details	Hours (Pacific Time)
Phone (US/Canada)	1-800-555-0142	Mon-Fri 8am-8pm; Sat 9am-5pm
Phone (UK)	+44 20 7946 0142	Mon-Fri 9am-5pm GMT
Email	support@northwind-demo.example	Response within 24 hours
Live chat	northwind-demo.example/chat	Daily 7am-10pm
Refund status line	1-800-555-0177	24/7 automated
Mail	Returns Dept., 200 Cascade Way, Portland, OR 97201, USA	N/A
Escalations	escalations@northwind-demo.example	Response within 2 business days

19.1 Escalation path

- Level 1: Customer Care Agent - resolves most issues in one contact.
- Level 2: Team Lead - refunds over $100, policy exceptions.
- Level 3: Customer Experience Manager - refunds over $500, complex disputes.
- Level 4: Executive Resolution Office - legal threats, regulatory complaints, media.

19.2 Service-level commitments

Request type	Target
First response by email	24 hours
First response by chat	Under 2 minutes
Resolution of standard refund query	Within 3 business days
Escalated complaint resolution	10 business days

20. Revision History and Sample Case Studies

20.1 Revision history

Version	Date	Change
4.2	Jan 1, 2026	Extended holiday window; added Keep It policy under $40
4.1	Aug 15, 2025	Added Gear Care Plan subscription terms
4.0	Mar 1, 2025	Gold member window raised from 45 to 60 days
3.5	Nov 10, 2024	Introduced 5% store-credit bonus
3.0	Jan 5, 2024	Restructured policy; added international section

20.2 Sample case studies

Case A - Wrong size, within window. Maria ordered a $120 jacket (order NW-10482391) and received it on June 3. On June 20 she requested a return as it did not fit. She used the prepaid label ($6.95 deducted). Refund issued: $113.05 to her Visa, plus tax refunded proportionally.

Case B - Defective tent zipper. Daniel bought a $349 tent on May 1 and discovered a broken zipper on May 12. He reported it with photos. Northwind issued a free label and sent a replacement tent with expedited shipping. Total cost to customer: $0.

Case C - Late return, Gold member. Priya (Gold) returned a $79 pair of boots on day 52. Because Gold members have 60 days, a full refund of $79 was issued with free return shipping.

Case D - Final Sale item. Tom attempted to return a $25 Final Sale fleece after 10 days. The request was declined under Section 5. As a goodwill gesture, a 10% discount code was offered.

Case E - Subscription accident. Lena was charged $49 for Rewards Plus renewal on Feb 3 and contacted support on Feb 9. She received a full pro-rated refund as she had not used any benefits in that period.

Case F - International return. Hans in Germany returned a EUR 150 sleeping bag within 20 days. VAT was refunded; return shipping of EUR 18 was paid by the customer. Refund issued in EUR within 5 business days of receipt.

End of document. All content is fictional and provided for software testing only.